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CRIB NOTES

A Cheat Sheet for Time-Pressed Readers Who Need Help Now

IF YOU'RE OVERWHELMED by the idea of delving into chapter after chapter on personal finance, this section's for you. The advice below cuts to the chase and puts you on the road to a solid financial life. Adopting even one or two of these strategies will leave you ahead of the game, whether the economy is soaring or suffering.

Of course, as someone's mother once said, cheaters only cheat themselves. And while this chapter is a good launching pad, ignoring the remaining nine chapters is a little like relying on the *Cliffs-Notes* version of *Macbeth*: You'll get the basic plot line but never understand what all the fuss is about. Still, the following will give you the basics. I've tried to list them in rough order of importance, but your priorities will depend on your own situation.

1. Insure yourself against financial ruin.

There's been lots of talk recently about the health insurance crisis, but not much action. As a result, nearly 20 million people (18 to 34 years old) are uninsured. If you're one of them, you need to figure out a way to get some coverage. And even if you're insured through your job, you need to be smart about the choices you make. The right health insurance will protect